

Metric Comparability Rules

1. Purpose

Each state runs its own child protective services system and they do not all collect or report data the same way. Before our team can fairly compare states and grade them, we need a shared set of rules for what can and cannot be compared. This document establishes those rules. It will be updated once Allen Huang delivers the cleaned data source list at our first weekly meeting on September 24th

2. Why Comparing CPS Data is Tricky

The same metric can mean different things in different states. One state might count every phone call to a hotline as a report while another only counts cases that were formally opened for investigation. If we compare those two numbers without flagging the difference, our evaluation would be misleading. These rules make sure we never compare things that are not actually the same.

3. The Rules

Rule 1:

Before comparing a metric across states we confirm both states define it the same way. If they do not, that metric is labeled Not Directly Comparable and we note the reason.

Rule 2:

We do not compare 2019 data from one state to 2022 data from another. If data is missing for a specific year in one state we note it as a gap and move on

Rule 3:

A larger state will always have higher raw numbers. To compare states of different sizes fairly we convert numbers to rates per 1,000 children.

Rule 4:

If a state did not report a metric we label it as Data Not Available. We never use a zero to fill a gap because zero means zero cases reported which is completely different from data not being submitted.

Rule 5:

If the data is too thin or inconsistent to support a grade we do not assign one. We document why and flag it for the team to revisit when better data is available.

4. How We Label Each Metric

Once Allen delivers the data source list every metric will get one of three labels:

Directly Comparable means the metric is defined and collected the same way across states and can be compared as is.

Conditionally Comparable means the metric is mostly consistent but differs in some states. We note which states differ and how.

Not Directly Comparable means the metric cannot be fairly compared without major caveats. We explain why and do not silently compare it.

5. Next Steps

This document will be updated after September 24th once Allen shares the list of data sources he has been putting together. At that point we will go through each metric and label it based on what the data actually shows.